ideas of rulership and Akbar's own eventual vision of his authority. It was an evolving vision, however; there was a decade to go, at least, before Abul Fazl began putting it into words in the *Akbarnama*. For now, Akbar and his new friends were still experimenting.

For now, in Iqtidar Alam Khan's words, the mahzar was not an assertion of universal authority, nor even of universal religious authority, but rather 'the final and . . . most blatant of Akbar's measures to placate and win over orthodox Muslim opinion in India', which he had been wooing ever since the Uzbek revolt some fifteen years ago. And, as such, it was 'a debacle'.

Far from placating anyone, the document created a loud and immediate controversy. Even Abul Fazl acknowledges the explosion of criticism: Akbar hated Islam, had adopted Shia beliefs, had become a brahmin, wanted to be God Himself – 'the stupid denizens of the demon-haunted land of ignorance indulge[d] in foolish talk', 'every faction went about in the streets of ignorance . . . spreading calumnies', on 'every side there arose the dust of commotion'.

But what basis did these '[a]ssemblies of wickedness' and slander have, asks Abul Fazl. Take the matter of disdaining Islam or Muhammad: it was crystal clear that Akbar honoured the Prophet's family – why else would he excuse, indeed forbid, the sayyids in his court, the Prophet's descendants, from prostrating before him?

That the emperor had embraced Shiism was equally ludicrous! It might be, yes, that many Persians – many of them Shia – held high positions in court, but Central Asians were promoted too – were such honours 'hidden from . . . bigoted eyes' or wilfully ignored? To say that Akbar has turned 'to the Brahman religion' because he 'received Hindu sages into his intimacy, and increased . . . the rank of Hindus' – Abul Fazl could only shake his head in despair.

Badauni may have been amongst those making this last charge. Years later, he would write of the 'accursed Birbar' that the brahmin poet was trying to convince Akbar to worship the sun, and 'fire, water, stones, and trees, and all natural objects, even down to cows and their dung'; to start wearing caste markings and the 'Brahmanical thread'.

But it was absurd, Abul Fazl protested, an 'improper notion' with no foundation except that Akbar treated Hindus well 'for the good of the country'. And why not? The emperor 'was not only kind to them but an